

KEY DEVELOPMENT

THE ISLAMIC EMPIRES AT WAR

The Muslim empires of the Ottomans, Mughals, and Safavids ruled a large swathe of Eurasia in the 16th and 17th centuries. Their armies combined Asian tribal heritage, reflected in the importance of horsemen, with gunpowder weapons.

The Mughals originated from Central Asia. Led by Zahir-ud-Din Babur, they conquered Afghanistan and northern India in the early 16th century, founding the Mughal Empire. Under Babur's successors, Mughal rule extended over the Indian subcontinent through near-constant campaigning.

The Mughal emperors recruited nomadic tribesmen from Central Asia, who fought as light horsemen with powerful composite bows. The army also absorbed the forces of conquered Indian states such as the Rajputs – aristocratic Hindu warriors armed with swords and daggers. Other Indian nobles supplied peasant infantry from their lands.

Mughal foot soldiers carried matchlock muskets, made by imitating foreign models; they also used brass and bronze cannon. In battle, musket- or spear-armed infantry lined up alongside field guns to form a block in front of the commanders, who sat on elephants that served as mobile command posts. Light horsemen on the flanks rode forward to shower the enemy with arrows, before the armoured cavalry in the centre charged with mace, sword, and lance. Their engineers built roads and mined under walls during sieges. Their main weakness was their infantry, a low-status, undisciplined rabble.

THE OTTOMANS

The Ottoman Turks were originally from Central Asia but, by 1500, they had ruled most of Turkey and the Balkans for over 100 years. In the 16th century, they extended their empire into Hungary, west Asia to the Persian border, Egypt, and North Africa.

The Ottoman army comprised infantry, cavalry, and artillery. Their elite infantry were Janissaries, seized as children from Christian families in the Balkans and raised as Muslim slaves. They carried firearms, and formed a disciplined corps of musket troops as part of the sultan's household guard. The household troops also featured a core of cavalry, the *sipahis*, who served in return for the right to raise rent from land. With mail-and-plate armour,

lances, javelins, and swords, they were supported by lighter horsemen with composite bows, known as *akinji*, who acted as scouts, raiders, and skirmishers. The power of Ottoman cannon was famous, and their artillery boasted almost 3,000 gunners by the late 16th century. Their navy, meanwhile, dominated the eastern Mediterranean.

THE SAFAVIDS

The Safavids came to power in Persia in 1501. At first, their army consisted of tribal horsemen, the Kizilbash. Lacking firearms, they were defeated by the Ottomans along the border of their two empires. But the Safavid monarch Shah Abbas (ruled 1587–1629), created a standing army that combined cavalry with musket-armed infantry and gunpowder artillery, drawing on European expertise. This more balanced force kept the Safavids in power until 1732.



▲ MUGHAL WAR ELEPHANT

Elephants were widely used in Mughal armies. Commanders rode them into combat, and used them both as heavy cavalry and as vantage points from which to survey and direct the battle.

◀ OTTOMAN JANISSARIES

Elite Janissaries head for war on horseback to the beat of drums. Ottoman soldiers were noted for their good discipline and morale.

KEY FIGURE

SULEYMAN I

1494–1566

Suleyman the Magnificent ruled the Ottoman Empire from 1520. He alternated campaigns in Europe with attacks on Safavid Persia, and his triumphs included the conquest of Hungary in 1526, and the capture of Baghdad in 1534. He failed, however, in a bid to take the island of Malta in 1565.



▲ In his younger years, Suleyman was an imposing figure, known for his chivalry as well as his valour. He later suffered from poor health.

“I am the sultan of sultans, the sovereign of sovereigns, the shadow of god on earth”

SULEYMAN I, IN A LETTER TO THE KING OF FRANCE, 1536